

NATURE OF RELIGIOUS LANGUAGE

TWO-AXIS CONTROL — UNIVOCAL, EQUIVOCAL AND ANALOGICAL — SYMBOL, NEGATION AND INDICATION — COGNITIVE SPECTRUM — VERIFICATION AND FALSIFICATION — USE, SELF-INVOLVEMENT AND FORMS

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis. Each card uses a concept-appropriate structure; the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

PRIMARY CORE FLOW

SUBORDINATE EXTRA

APPROVAL / REVIEW

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • source generation g11 repaired in place; prior artifacts unchanged outside the scoped current generation

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles

00

STAGE 00 TWO-AXIS CONTROL

TWO-AXIS CONTROLRELIGIOUS LANGUAGE HAS TWO DISTINCT QUESTIONSAXIS 1 — MODE OF PREDICATIONAXIS 2 — LOGICAL STATUS“GOD IS GOOD” MAY BE ANALOGICAL AND COGNITIVE“I COMMIT MYSELF TO GOD” MAY BE MEANINGFUL WITHOUT

NEVER MERGE HOW WORDS MEAN WITH WHETHER UTTERANCES ASSERT

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- RELIGIOUS LANGUAGE HAS TWO DISTINCT QUESTIONS
- AXIS 1 — MODE OF PREDICATION: univocal

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- AXIS 2 — LOGICAL STATUS: cognitive/factual
- “God is good” may be analogical AND cognitive

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- “I commit myself to God” may be meaningful without describing an observable object
- NEVER merge how words mean with whether utterances assert facts.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: A complete answer must keep two axes separate: how religious predicates refer and whether religious utterances assert facts.

01

STAGE 01 UNIVOCAL, EQUIVOCAL AND ANALOGICAL

UNIVOCAL, EQUIVOCAL AND ANALOGICALSAME MEANING FOR GOD AND CREATURESCLARITY, BUT RISKS ANTHROPOMORPHISMWHOLLY DIFFERENT MEANINGPROTECTS TRANSCENDENCE, BUT BLOCKS KNOWLEDGE/INFERENCERELATED MEANING GROUNDED IN CAUSAL PARTICIPATION

ANALOGY OF ATTRIBUTION/PROPORTIONALITY; CREATURELY GOODNESS REFLECTS DIVINE SOURCESOME UNIVOCAL CONCEPT OF BEING IS NEEDED FOR VALID

SYSTEM / DOCTRINEUNIVOCAL: same meaning for God and creatures — clarity, but risks anthropomorphismEQUIVOCAL: wholly different meaning — protects transcendence, but blocks knowledge/inference

DECISIVE DISTINCTIONANALOGICAL: related meaning grounded in causal participationAQUINAS: analogy of attribution/proportionality; creaturely goodness reflects divine source

EVALUATION / TRAPSCOTUS: some univocal concept of being is needed for valid reasoning about God tension: enough continuity for truth, enough difference for transcendence.

SYSTEM / DOCTRINE

- UNIVOCAL: same meaning for God and creatures — clarity, but risks anthropomorphism
- EQUIVOCAL: wholly different meaning — protects transcendence, but blocks knowledge/inference

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

- ANALOGICAL: related meaning grounded in causal participation
- AQUINAS: analogy of attribution/proportionality; creaturely goodness reflects divine source

EVALUATION / TRAP

- SCOTUS: some univocal concept of being is needed for valid reasoning about God tension: enough continuity for truth,
- enough difference for transcendence.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Scotus demands a minimal univocal concept for valid inference, while Aquinas insists that causal participation secures continuity without placing God and creatures in one genus.

02

STAGE 02 SYMBOL, NEGATION AND INDICATION

SYMBOL, NEGATION AND INDICATIONSYMBOL PARTICIPATES IN THE REALITY IT DISCLOSES AND OPENSVIA NEGATIVAGOD IS NOT FINITE, COMPOSITE OR DEPENDENTSUPEREMINENT TRANSCENDENCEINDIAN “NETI NETI”NOT THIS, NOT THIS; REMOVES FINITE OBJECTIFICATION

INDIRECT MEANING WHEN LITERAL SENSE FAILS LIMIT

VIA NEGATIVA: God is not finite, composite or dependent

TILLICH: symbol participates in the reality it discloses and opens levels of reality/self symbols are

PSEUDO-DIONYSIUS: affirmation — negation — supereminent transcendence

INDIAN “NETI NETI”: not this, not this; removes finite objectification

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- TILLICH: symbol participates in the reality it discloses and opens levels of reality/self symbols are living and can die; they are not arbitrary signs
- VIA NEGATIVA: God is not finite, composite or dependent

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- PSEUDO-DIONYSIUS: affirmation — negation — supereminent transcendence
- INDIAN “NETI NETI”: not this, not this; removes finite objectification

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- LAŚAṆA/indication: indirect meaning when literal sense fails limit: pure negation must retain some positive orientation or reference disappears.
- TILLICH: symbol participates in the reality it discloses and opens levels of reality/self symbols are living and can die; they are not arbitrary signs

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: For Tillich, a religious symbol participates in the reality it discloses and opens levels of reality and self otherwise inaccessible, but it must remain distinguishable from mere emotional projection.

03

STAGE 03 COGNITIVE SPECTRUM

COGNITIVE SPECTRUMCOGNITIVE REALISMGOD-TALK STATES TRUTHS THAT MAY BE WARRANTED OR FALSELANGUAGE EXPRESSES A FORM OF LIFE, ORIENTATION OR CONSTRUCTIONARTICULATES ATTITUDE/COMMITMENTPRAYER, VOW, CONFESSION AND BLESSING DO SOMETHING

FORMS IDENTITY AND DISCLOSES A WORLD OF MEANING UTTERANCES

SYSTEM / DOCTRINECOGNITIVE REALISM: God-talk states truths that may be warranted or falseANTI-REALISM/NON-REALISM: language expresses a form of life, orientation or construction

DECISIVE DISTINCTIONEXPRESSIVISM: articulates attitude/commitmentPERFORMATIVISM: prayer, vow, confession and blessing do something

EVALUATION / TRAPMYTHIC/NARRATIVE: forms identity and discloses a world of meaning utterances can have several functionsfunctional richness does not itself settle reference.

SYSTEM / DOCTRINE

- COGNITIVE REALISM: God-talk states truths that may be warranted or false
- ANTI-REALISM/NON-REALISM: language expresses a form of life, orientation or construction

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

- EXPRESSIVISM: articulates attitude/commitment
- PERFORMATIVISM: prayer, vow, confession and blessing do something

EVALUATION / TRAP

- MYTHIC/NARRATIVE: forms identity and discloses a world of meaning utterances can have several functions
- functional richness does not itself settle reference.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Non-cognitive theories clarify commitment and form of life, but they become reductive if they deny that believers also intend claims about reality.

04

STAGE 04 VERIFICATION AND FALSIFICATION

VERIFICATION AND FALSIFICATIONCOGNITIVELY MEANINGFUL FACTUAL CLAIMS MUST BE ANALYTIC OR EMPIRICALLYTRADITIONAL GOD-TALK APPEARS MEANINGLESS, NOT MERELY FALSEESCHATOLOGICAL VERIFICATION — CELESTIAL-CITY PARABLE; CONFIRMATION MAY OCCUR AFTER

BELIEVERS LET “GOD LOVES US” DIE BY A THOUSANDRELIGIOUS BLIK IS UNFALSIFIABLE ORIENTATION YET MEANINGFULPARTISAN TRUSTS STRANGER DESPITE COUNTER-EVIDENCE; COMMITMENT REMAINS EVIDENTIALLY TESTEDWHAT COUNTS AGAINST THE CLAIM, AND WHAT KIND OF

DOCTRINE / CLAIM

- AYER: cognitively meaningful factual claims must be analytic or empirically verifiable
- traditional God-talk appears meaningless, not merely false
- HICK: eschatological verification — celestial-city parable; confirmation may occur after death

OBJECTION / PRESSURE

- FLEW: believers let “God loves us” die by a thousand qualifications
- HARE: religious blik is unfalsifiable orientation yet meaningful
- MITCHELL: partisan trusts stranger despite counter-evidence

REPLY / RESIDUAL

- commitment remains evidentially tested key test: what counts against the claim, and what kind of claim is it?

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The verification and falsification debates test whether religious claims exclude any possible state of affairs; a meaningful theology must specify evidential risk without demanding laboratory verification.

05

STAGE 05 USE, SELF-INVOLVEMENT AND FORMS OF LIFE

USE, SELF-INVOLVEMENT AND FORMS OF LIFE MEANING IS USE WITHIN A LANGUAGE-GAME AND FORM OFRELIGIOUS ASSERTIONS EXPRESS INTENTION TO FOLLOW AN AGAPEISTIC WAYSAME WORD, DIFFERENT GRAMMAR“FATHER” BIOLOGICAL/SECULAR“FATHER” RELATIONAL RELIGIOUS USE

“CREATION” TEMPORAL MANUFACTUREDEPENDENCE ON ULTIMATE SOURCE OBJECTION

BRAITHWAITE: religious assertions express intention to follow an agapeistic way of life

WITTGENSTEIN: meaning is use within a language-game and form of life prayer, lament, confession and

SAME WORD, DIFFERENT GRAMMAR

“father” biological/secular

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- WITTGENSTEIN: meaning is use within a language-game and form of life prayer, lament, confession and worship are not failed scientific hypotheses
- BRAITHWAITE: religious assertions express intention to follow an agapeistic way of life
- SAME WORD, DIFFERENT GRAMMAR

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- “father” biological/secular
- “Father” relational religious use
- “creation” temporal manufacture

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- dependence on ultimate source objection: use may explain intelligibility, but cannot by itself guarantee truth or protect critique.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Religious and secular language share grammar, but religious use is distinguished by its ultimate referent, self-involving force, communal practice and resistance to exhaustive literalisation.

06

STAGE 06 MYSTICISM, ADVAITA AND PLURALISM BRIDGES

MYSTICISM, ADVAITA AND PLURALISM BRIDGESINEFFABILITY PRESSURES LITERAL DESCRIPTION; PARADOX AND SYMBOL POINT BEYONDNIRGUNA BRAHMAN BEYOND LIMITING PREDICATES; SAGUNA LANGUAGE VALID EMPIRICALLYDIFFERENT CONCEPTUAL SCHEMES MAY REFER TO OR CONSTRUCT DIVERSE

TRANSLATION WITHOUT ERASING DOCTRINAL DIFFERENCE ANSWERCOMPARE REFERENCE, PREDICATION, FUNCTION AND LIFE-CONTEXT SEPARATELY.

ADVAITA: nirguna Brahman beyond limiting predicates

MYSTICISM: ineffability pressures literal description; paradox and symbol point beyond concepts

saguna language valid empirically mahāvākya interpretation uses implication to remove incompatible literal attributes

PLURALISM: different conceptual schemes may refer to or construct diverse ultimates challenge: translation without erasing

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- MYSTICISM: ineffability pressures literal description; paradox and symbol point beyond concepts
- ADVAITA: nirguna Brahman beyond limiting predicates

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- saguna language valid empirically mahāvākya interpretation uses implication to remove incompatible literal attributes
- PLURALISM: different conceptual schemes may refer to or construct diverse ultimates challenge: translation without erasing doctrinal difference answer

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- compare reference, predication, function and life-context separately.
- MYSTICISM: ineffability pressures literal description; paradox and symbol point beyond concepts

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Analogy preserves ordered similarity, symbol mediates participation and negation removes creaturely limitation; each seeks meaningful reference without literal anthropomorphism.

07

STAGE 07 PYQ ANSWER ARCHITECTURE

PYQ ANSWER ARCHITECTUREIDENTIFY UTTERANCEANALYSE MODE OF PREDICATIONCLASSIFY LOGICAL STATUSNAMED THEORY (AQUINAS/TILLICH/AYER/FLEW/HARE/MITCHELL/WITTGENSTEIN)STRONGEST OBJECTION/REPLYINDIAN ANALOGY OR NEGATION BRIDGE

RELIGIOUS LANGUAGE NEED NOT BE LITERAL TO BE MEANINGFUL

IDENTIFY utterance — analyse mode of predication — classify logical status

named theory (Aquinas/Tillich/Ayer/Flew/Hare/Mitchell/Wittgenstein)

strongest objection/reply — Indian analogy or negation bridge — verdict

CLOSE: religious language need not be literal to be meaningful, but analogy, symbol, use or

adequacy requires semantic intelligibility, critical vulnerability and lived function.

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- IDENTIFY utterance — analyse mode of predication — classify logical status
- named theory (Aquinas/Tillich/Ayer/Flew/Hare/Mitchell/Wittgenstein)

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- strongest objection/reply — Indian analogy or negation bridge — verdict
- CLOSE: religious language need not be literal to be meaningful, but analogy, symbol, use or commitment cannot automatically secure factual truth

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- adequacy requires semantic intelligibility, critical vulnerability and lived function.
- IDENTIFY utterance — analyse mode of predication — classify logical status

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: A strong answer identifies the utterance’s function, applies the relevant theory, tests its strongest objection and closes with a qualified account of cognitive content.

E

EXTRA SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

OPTIONAL ADVANCED ENRICHMENTADVANCED-DOSSIER RECONCILIATION — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]DOCTRINE STATEMENT.PREDICATES SUCH AS GOOD AND WISE APPLY TO GOD(1) CREATURES DEPEND CAUSALLY ON GOD AND DISPLAY PERFECTIONS

(2) EFFECTS RESEMBLE CAUSES WITHOUT MATCHING THEIR MODE(3) PERFECTION TERMS CAN THEREFORE SIGNIFY TRULY WHILE THEIRPRESUPPOSITION. CAUTION

OPTIONAL SOURCE WITNESS

- Advanced-dossier reconciliation — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]
- Doctrine statement.
- Predicates such as good and wise apply to God neither in exactly the creaturely sense nor in a wholly unrelated sense, but analogically.
- Argument.

ADVANCED OBJECTION

- (1) Creatures depend causally on God and display perfections
- (2) effects resemble causes without matching their mode
- (3) perfection terms can therefore signify truly while their mode of possession differs infinitely.
- Presupposition. CAUTION: Causal participation warrants semantic continuity and pure perfections can be separated from creaturely limitation.

COMPARATIVE NUANCE

- Distinction.
- Analogy of attribution relates secondary instances to a primary source
- proportionality compares relations according to distinct modes of being.
- Canonical example.

OPTIONAL STATUS — This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.